

losses. I have had to suffer quite a few times, but the two or three bets that pay off more than compensated for my losses in other stocks,' JC said.

JC had warmed to me and was now freely talking about his trades.

I asked him why he had turned bullish on Aban Lloyd (a company that operates oil rigs) after having been bearish on it for a long time. I knew the reason, but I wanted to hear it from him. JC had been bearish on Aban for many months. But he lost a lot of money as the stock price kept rising even as he short-sold Aban futures. Then JC got lucky. The company's main revenue grosser, an oil rig off the Venezuelan coast, sank. The stock price halved within a week, and JC not only recouped his losses, but made a tidy profit too. Of late, the stock price was on an upswing, and had recovered significantly from the lows of the year even if it was still some way off from its recent highs.

'Having worked with some of the best market operators, I thought you would have spotted that trick, Lala,' JC said, once again smiling. 'The stock has bounced because I have covered most of my short positions,' he said, looking pleased with himself. 'Of course, the company is doing poorly. But I am unable to hammer the price down further because all the buyers have fled. I have to attract some buyers before I start hammering down the price once again. To bring them back, I have to create an illusion that the stock price is set to move up,' he said.

Earlier during the year, I had heard that JC had heavily short-sold the futures of a Mumbai-based realty company. The promoters, in collusion with a bull operator, had pushed up prices and had managed to hold them at a certain level, forcing JC to buy back the futures at nearly three times the price he had sold them for. The talk in market circles was that JC had suffered a loss of Rs 40 crore on that trade. Though it was impolite on my part, I brought the matter up.

'I heard that trade cost you a packet.'

'A little, but not as much as the market would like to believe,' JC said, looking me in the eye. But JC made no bones about the fact that he was mad as hell at the operator who helped the promoter jack up the price.

'But why make it personal?' I asked JC. 'If that operator had declined, the promoter would have enlisted somebody else for that job.'

'Maybe. But for some reason I took a dislike to that fellow after the incident. Since then I made it a point to short the stocks on which he would be long,' JC admitted.